Abdullah Al Zahid

Toronto, ON | (780) 982-3680 | azahid1@ualberta.ca | linkedin.com/in/abdullah-al-zahid

October 22, 2026

Hiring Manager
Transportation Engineering and Operations
Strathcona County

Re: GIS Specialist II, Transportation

Dear Hiring Manager,

I would like to apply for the GIS Specialist II, Transportation position. I am an Assistant Planner in Transportation Planning at the City of Toronto, with a master's degree in transportation engineering from the University of Alberta, where my thesis used GIS to study how much traffic a community's roads could carry in a wildfire evacuation.

At the City, GIS and Python are how I keep the division's data usable. I build and maintain the road and right-of-way datasets that Transportation Planning depends on, including a right-of-way width dataset for all city roads, built with QGIS, MapBox and JavaScript from sources that used to be scattered. I also built the Transportation Data Dashboard, which brought several years of survey data into one validated source in place of a report rebuilt by hand each quarter. I analyze travel and network data for trends and gaps and turn the results into recommendations, and I explain them to planners and engineers who are not GIS users.

At Metrolinx I set up a command line workflow that pre-simulated slow orders in batches, cutting turnaround on scenario requests from days to hours, and built the Crew Variance Tool, a Python application that read large JSON operations files and summarised speed profiles and run-time variance across subdivisions.

I should be straightforward about the gaps. My professional GIS experience is shorter than the five years the posting asks for, and it is mixed in with other planning work rather than being the whole of a role. I have not supervised or coached staff, and I do not hold a GISP or Esri certification. I have worked mainly in ArcGIS Pro and QGIS and have not administered an enterprise geodatabase or run a GIS service for a whole department. I am applying because the work is transportation data and spatial analysis, which is where my experience sits, and I would be glad to learn the rest.

Thank you for considering my application.

Sincerely,

Abdullah Al Zahid

Abdullah Al Zahid